פרשת וירא. If we look at the פרשה in the context of the parshiyos that surround it, there's a remarkable difference between the three פרשיות of לך לך, וירא, and חיי שרה. The first few words of לך לך are וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל אַבְרָם. The first three words of פרשת חיי שרה are וַיִּהְיוּ חַיֵּי שָׂרָה. However, פרשת וירא starts off without mentioning אברהם אבינו's name: וַיֵּרָא אֵלָיו ה' בְּאֵלֹנֵי מַמְרֵא. That's a rather unusual way to start a פרשה. Who are we talking about? We're talking about אברהם. If you go back to the end of לך לך, אברם's name is not even in the last pasuk, it's in second-to-last pasuk, בְּעֶצֶם הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה נִמּוֹל אַבְרָהָם. Then it says וַיֵּרָא אֵלָיו. Why do we use a pronoun?

The ספר אוצר פלאות התורה, a wonderful ספר which I've quoted many times, brings down a fascinating מנהג. When a person is visiting a חולה, one should not say his name in his presence. He brings it down from the ילקוט ראובני, quoted in a sefer called סודי רזייא. If someone goes in to visit a חולה, he should not mention him by name. He should say רפואה שלמה and ask "How are you? What can I do to help you? Let me help clean up the room a little bit." The רמב"ן writes that it's very important to help keep the place clean and neat, a visitor should make it his business to clean up the house, and that helps the חולה get better. In fact, there's a גמרא in נדרים דף מ עמוד א that מַעֲשֶׂה בְּתַלְמִיד אֶחָד מִתַּלְמִידֵי רַבִּי עֲקִיבָא שֶׁחָלָה, and people did not come to visit him. רבי עקיבא came in to visit him, and he helped to clean him and clean the room, and the sick person said, "רַבִּי, הֶחֱיִיתַנִי". So there are a number of things you should do on a ביקור חולים visit. But one of the things you don't do is mention his name. And that's exactly what happens here, וַיֵּרָא אֵלָיו ה'. It doesn't say וַיֵּרָא אל אברהם to indicate that הקדוש ברוך הוא did not mention his name when he came to visit him.

The מגן אברהם writes in the name of the מהרי"ל, a very early פוסק quoted in רש"י many times, that if someone is מבקש רחמים for his friend, you don't mention his name while in front of him. But if you're מתפלל while not in front of him, then you should mention his name. As we all know, we mention the name and the mother's name. The חתם סופר writes in מסכת נדרים that when a person mentions a חולה's name, there is a התעוררות of דין on him. Therefore, it's a הפסד to mention the sick person's name while in his presence.

Now, he brings another point from the ספר טעמי המנהגים that another possibility is that there may very well be a גזר דין against ראובן בן יעקב, so it would be important not to mention his name at a ביקור חולים visit. In serious situations, one of the techniques we have to disrupt that is to change his name, because the גזר דין against ראובן בן יעקב is not the same thing as a גזר דין against ראובן רפאל בן יעקב, for example. When we change the name, that גזר דין is no longer applicable to this person because this is a different person with a different name.

Now, another fascinating aspect of this brought down from the Munkatcher Rebbe, the מנחת אלעזר, זכותו יגן עלינו, and is mentioned in a number of ספרים of his descendants, is that when we make the מי שברך for a חולה in shul, not to say the word החולה. We say מי שברך אבותינו אברהם יצחק ויעקב הוא יברך את, and the לשון in every סידור says החולה, and then they give the names. Rabbi Oelbaum quoted this a number of years ago, and we in our shul changed our מנהג to not say the word החולה, we don't want to label this person as a חולה. The sefer דרכי חיים ושלום brings that Chazal say in מסכת שבת that a person should always be מבקש רחמים that he should not get sick, and if, חס ושלום, someone does get sick, we say to him, הוי זכות והיפטר - Find a זכות. However, once we label him a חולה, we're being מקיים that this is his status. That's not a זכות, that's cementing him into that category of חולה. Therefore, it's an excellent suggestion to leave out the word when you say the מי שברך, which we've done in our shul for many years. Whoever's a גבאי who hears that, you're more than welcome to follow this מנהג or at least bring it up with your local Orthodox rabbi.

The point is a person's name is that person. We know that it's a very important ענין when a baby is born to give a name that's appropriate and will be a זכות for him. We don't want that same name חס ושלום to be a חובה to him. Therefore, if חס ושלום a situation happens where someone gets sick, we have to follow these

suggestions, and they will help them have a רפואה שלמה. All the חולים in כלל ישראל should have a רפואה שלמה במהרה, and all the healthy people should stay healthy and be געזונט און שטארק.

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